

POV: You Still Live With Your Parents at 30 — While Everyone Else Pays Someone Else's Mortgage

Narration script · ARC format · Target 4,000 words · Final 3,905 words · ~24 min at 2.7 words/sec

It's 7:40 on a Saturday night and you're standing on a rooftop downtown, holding a drink you didn't pay for. It's Marcus's thirtieth birthday. His building. His roof. His heated pool glowing blue behind everyone's heads. Your phone buzzes in your pocket. You don't need to look. You already know what it says. One line. A balance. Two words after it. Paid in full.

You keep it in your pocket.

There are five of you up here. The same five since sophomore year. Marcus in a linen shirt with the tags still on the inside collar. Theo and Jenna holding hands, a little tired, a little proud, the way people look when they own a house. And Priya, who notices everything and says almost none of it.

Marcus taps a spoon against his glass. He gives a speech about thirty. About building something. About how everyone up here made it. He raises his drink toward Theo and Jenna's house, toward his own building, toward the city. When his glass swings past you, it slows down for half a second. Then it keeps going.

The waiter comes by with a tablet. Marcus waves him off. Tonight's on me, he says. Then he turns to you, grinning, warm, a little loud. And you're still at your mom's, right? Still in the room with the stars on the ceiling?

Everybody laughs. Not mean. Just familiar. You laugh too.

Jenna touches your arm. If you ever need a place, she says, we have the spare room now. Seriously. No rush.

You say thanks. You mean it.

You're thirty. You still sleep in the bedroom you slept in at nine. And sitting on that rooftop, you have more money than anyone holding a glass. Not more income. More money. The kind that stays.

None of them know. Not Marcus. Not Theo. Not Jenna. Not even Priya.

Here's what nobody tells you about the years everyone pities you. They don't feel like a plan. They feel like an apology you keep making at every dinner. This is how the friend everyone

assumed was stuck turned out to be the only one not paying for someone else's house. And why saying it out loud kept getting harder.

Eight years earlier, you're twenty-two, standing in your parents' driveway with everything you own in four cardboard boxes and a laundry basket.

You have a degree. A job offer. \$41,000 a year. You also have \$19,000 in student loans and \$2,500 in a checking account. Your net worth sits around negative sixteen thousand. You tell everyone the same thing. Just for a few months. Just until I get settled.

Your mother has cleared out the closet. She's washed the old comforter. She hasn't touched the ceiling. Thirty-one glow-in-the-dark stars, stuck up there when you were nine. They still light up faintly when you turn the lamp off.

The spare key is on the hook by the door. Same faded blue lanyard from high school. Your mother hands it to you like it's a formality. Like you never gave it back.

The first night, you lie under the stars and open a rental app. A one-bedroom across town. \$1,450 a month. Plus utilities. Plus parking. Call it \$1,700. That's what being a grown-up costs in this city. That's the number everyone your age is paying.

And then you make a decision so small it feels like nothing.

You'll pay it anyway.

Every month, \$1,700 leaves your paycheck, just like it would if you had your own place. \$500 goes to your parents. They try to refuse it. Your mother pushes the first envelope back across the kitchen table. You push it back harder. She takes it the way people take something they plan to argue about later. The other \$1,200 disappears the morning the paycheck lands. Automatic. Gone before you can miss it.

One rule. Made once. So you'd never have to decide again.

You tell no one. There's no way to say it that doesn't sound like an excuse. I live with my parents, but it's on purpose isn't a sentence anyone believes at twenty-two.

The next morning, your father is at the kitchen table with his coffee and the newspaper he still pays for. He watches you pack a lunch in a reused takeout container. You sure about this? he asks. Not the living here. The other thing. He saw the envelope. He doesn't know what the rest of the money is doing. He just knows you're doing something. You say you're sure. You aren't. He nods and turns the page. He never asks again.

That first summer, Marcus throws a party at his new apartment. Exposed brick. A balcony. A dog-friendly building with no dog. Someone asks where everyone's living now, and the answers go around the circle like a toast. Downtown. Midtown. That place by the river. Then they get to you.

You say, I'm at my parents' for a bit.

And a small silence opens up. Not cruel. Just careful. The kind of silence people make around something they don't want to step on.

Then Theo asks the question. Not unkindly. Just curious.

So when are you moving out?

You say soon. Everyone nods. The conversation rolls on.

You'll hear that question for eight years.

Thanksgiving that year, it gets asked by people who don't love you as gently.

Your aunt Denise sets down a dish of sweet potatoes and asks, so where are you living now, honey? Before you can answer, your mother says, he's home with us, and something in the room adjusts. Your cousin Kyle is twenty-four. He just bought a truck. \$640 a month for seventy-two months. He announces the payment like it's a trophy. Your uncle claps him on the back. Then he looks at you, and the hand doesn't come. He just says, well, no rush, buddy. Everybody's on their own timeline. It's kind. It's also a verdict. You pass the rolls. You notice nobody asks you a single follow-up question for the rest of the night.

The first fourteen months, the \$1,200 doesn't build anything. It erases. Loan statements shrink. \$19,000. Then \$13,000. Then \$6,400. You make the last payment from your car in a grocery store parking lot on a Tuesday. The screen says balance zero. You sit there with the engine off. Nobody to tell. You drive home and eat leftovers at the same kitchen table you ate cereal at in fourth grade.

The next month, the \$1,200 finds a new home. An index fund. The first deposit buys a few shares of something you'll never see.

Then come the years where it looks like you made a mistake. Because everyone else's life starts happening on schedule. In public. With pictures.

Theo and Jenna buy a house at twenty-five. A small one with a red door and a backyard that floods when it rains. The group chat fills with paint swatches. Then a puppy. Then a photo of keys in Jenna's hand, a ribbon tied around them. Someone writes, adults. Thirty hearts follow.

Marcus moves again. A higher floor. A gym in the basement. A doorman who learns his name. His rent climbs to \$2,100. He mentions it the way people mention the price of a watch.

Your updates get smaller. Then they stop. What are you going to post? A photo of your mother's meatloaf? The ceiling?

You go on a date. Her name is Alana. She's funny and quick, and she likes the same terrible movie you do. Halfway through dinner she asks where you live. You tell her the truth. She says, oh. Just that. Oh. Her face doesn't change much. It just closes, gently, like a door being shut so it won't wake anyone. When the check comes, she reaches for her half before you can reach for all of it. Not rude. Efficient. You're being placed in a category, and the category doesn't get a second date.

You drive home and park in the same spot in the driveway. Your father's left the porch light on. He always does.

The rule runs the entire time. Every raise, half disappears into the account. \$1,200 becomes \$1,400. Then \$1,650. You never feel richer. You change a number in an app and go back to work.

At work, the team goes to lunch on Fridays. Everyone talks about rent the way people talk about weather. Somebody's landlord raised it \$150. Somebody else found a place with in-unit laundry for only \$1,900. Your manager, Greg, a nice man with three kids and a boat he never uses, turns to you. And where are you these days? You say you're at home for now. He nods slowly. At your review, he gives you the biggest raise on the team. He says it's for your work. Then he adds, quietly, maybe this helps you get your own place. He means well. He thinks he's paying for your escape. He doesn't know half of it will be in the account by Monday.

Two things happen in those years that you won't understand until later.

The first is an apartment.

You're twenty-five and you're tired of explaining yourself. So you go look at a loft downtown. Brick walls. Tall windows. A kitchen with a gas stove and a little shelf for spices you don't own. \$1,650 a month. You can afford it. That's the problem. It isn't reckless. It's just more.

The leasing agent is about your age. She's wearing a blazer and she's very good at her job. She slides the lease across a glass desk and sets a pen on top of it. Everything about the room says, you belong here. You pick up the pen.

And you stand there long enough that she starts to smile less.

You put the pen down. You say you need to think. She says the unit won't last. You say you understand.

That night the group chat lights up. Marcus on his balcony. City behind him. A caption with three fire emojis. And you lie under thirty-one plastic stars, wondering if you're building something or just getting very good at hiding from your own life. You don't feel disciplined. You feel behind.

Priya is the only one who ever gets close. At a bar that year, she watches you order water with lime while everyone else orders the second round. She doesn't make a joke about it. She just slides her fries toward the middle of the table, where you can reach them. Later, in the parking lot, she asks if you're okay for money. Not pity. Just a question. You tell her you're fine. She looks at your car, then at you, and says, okay. She doesn't believe you. She just decides not to push. You'll think about that parking lot for years.

The second thing, you almost miss.

Your father's hours get cut. Not fired. Just cut. Thirty hours a week instead of forty. Your parents don't tell you. You find out from the envelope on the counter with the bank's logo, opened and refolded too many times. The mortgage. \$1,180 a month. Eleven years left.

You don't ask. You just change one number. Starting that month, \$800 goes to your parents instead of \$500. You tell your mother it's because you eat more than you used to. She looks at you a long time. She doesn't argue.

You don't know it yet, but that \$800 isn't going to groceries. Your mother is sending every dollar of it straight to the principal on the house.

And for almost four years, the plan doesn't make you feel smart. It makes everyone else look like they started living years before you did. You have no way of knowing the distance between you is already turning around.

You're twenty-six when the market falls apart. Not a dip. A real one. The kind that leads the evening news in your parents' living room while your father shakes his head at the screen.

Over four bad months, your account loses twenty-two percent. At work, people say, did you see what the market did? in the voice you'd use for a car accident. A guy two desks over sells everything on a Thursday afternoon and goes home early. He tells you he's done gambling. You nod. You open the app at work and watch \$31,000 turn into \$24,000.

That year, you put in more than \$19,000. And in December the balance is lower than it was in January.

Theo's house is still standing. Marcus's view is still there. Their choices didn't evaporate. Yours look like they did.

You want to stop. You don't. Not because you're brave. Because the transfer was set up years ago, back before fear had a vote. It keeps buying while everything is on sale. You just can't feel that yet. It only feels like losing. That night you lie under the ceiling and count the stars. Thirty-one. Same as always. They're the only thing in your life that hasn't moved.

Somewhere in that stretch, Marcus gets drinks with you and looks at the blue lanyard hanging out of your jacket pocket. You still carry that thing? he says. It's from high school. Let me buy you a key ring at least.

You tell him it's lucky. He lets it go.

Then your car's transmission dies on the highway. \$2,300. The kind of bill that would have flattened you at twenty-two. You pay it from your checking account standing at the counter of the repair shop. The mechanic, an older man with grease in the creases of his knuckles, waits for you to flinch. Most people do. You don't. He looks at you a second longer than usual. You're three steps into the parking lot before you realize you weren't afraid. The fear just wasn't there. Somewhere in the boring years, without a date you could circle, it left.

By twenty-seven, the market turns. The shares you bought in the fire start doing what shares do. The account doesn't just recover. It passes everything it was before. \$80,000. Then \$100,000 on an ordinary Wednesday. You notice it the way you'd notice the weather.

And around that time, the reversal starts. Quiet. Invisible. Real.

Theo and Jenna's interest rate resets. Their payment jumps \$640 a month. The same number as Kyle's truck. You notice it. You don't say it. Then the basement floods, the one that always flooded, and this time it's \$9,000. Jenna mentions it at dinner like it's a joke. Theo doesn't laugh. They've been paying for five years and the bank still owns most of the red door.

At their Fourth of July barbecue, Theo stands at the grill a little too long after the burgers are done. He tells you they refinanced. Stretched it back out to thirty years to make the payment work. We'll own it when we're sixty-two, he says, and flips a burger that doesn't need flipping. He laughs. You laugh. Neither of you means it. Behind him, the backyard is still soft from the last flood.

Marcus's rent goes to \$2,900. He gets a letter slid under his door about the renewal. He shows it to you on his phone and says, it's fine, it's fine, the way people say it when it isn't. Four years in that building. You do the math in your head without meaning to. More than \$110,000 in rent. Every dollar of it paying down a stranger's mortgage. He owns the linen shirts. He owns the watch. He doesn't own a single brick. And the landlord he's never met just bought a second building.

Nobody failed. That's the part that matters. They just built lives that have to be fed. And the feeding never stops.

Yours, quietly, started feeding you.

You're twenty-eight when you read a line on a statement twice. Before a single new deposit, your account grew \$14,000 that year on its own. While you worked. While you slept under the stars. While you sat at the kitchen table listening to your father complain about the neighbor's leaf blower. Your salary is still the bigger number. But it isn't the only one working anymore.

That same winter, your father slips on the back steps carrying groceries. A broken hip. Surgery. Eight weeks of recovery. Your mother can't lift him alone.

And you're there. Not because you rearranged your life. Because you never left it. You hear him fall from upstairs. You're at the bottom of the steps in nine seconds. You drive him to the hospital in your repaired car. Every morning for eight weeks, you help him from the bed to the chair before work. Every night, you help him back.

The money you didn't spend on rent bought something you didn't know you were buying. Being in the house when it mattered.

That's the first time the whole strange arrangement feels like it was worth it. Not the balance. The nine seconds.

One night during his recovery, your mother sits across from you at the kitchen table with a pencil and the mortgage statement. She doesn't hide it this time. She slides it over. Look, she says. And she taps a number she's circled. Twenty-two payments left. It was supposed to be

eight more years. She doesn't say thank you. She doesn't have to. She just keeps her finger on the number a little longer than she needs to, like it might move if she lets go.

But something else starts happening too. Something you don't like.

Your mother's friends from church ask her about you. You can hear her through the kitchen wall one Sunday. He's figuring it out, she says. He's a late bloomer. He'll be fine. Her voice is the one she uses to defend things. And she's defending you. Because she doesn't know about the account. Nobody does.

You could walk in and end it. One sentence. You stand in the hallway with your hand on the wall. Then you go back upstairs.

You never chose to lie. You just never corrected anyone. And at some point those became the same thing.

Then it gets uglier.

Marcus calls one night. He's moving out. Somewhere cheaper. He's embarrassed about it, so he makes it about you. Hey, he says, why don't we get a two-bedroom together? I can cover the deposit. It'd be good for you. Get you out of there.

He's being generous. He's being kind. And he's offering to rescue you with money he doesn't have.

You could tell him the truth. You could pay the whole year's rent on a two-bedroom without blinking.

Instead you say, let me think about it. And you let him feel generous. And when you hang up, you notice you're smiling.

That's the part that scares you. You've started to enjoy it. Being underestimated. The private math at every table. Knowing what nobody knows. You catch yourself guarding the secret, not because you need to anymore, but because you like who you get to be inside it.

And it lands on you, lying under the stars. If you need everyone to think you're stuck, their opinion is still running your life. You just flipped the direction. For years, you refused to perform success. And somewhere along the way, you started performing failure just as hard.

Priya texts you the next morning. Out of nowhere. You okay? You've seemed far away lately.

You start typing the truth. The rule. The number. Eight years of it. You look at it for a long time.

Then you delete it and send a photo of your mother's meatloaf.

Which brings you back to the rooftop.

Marcus's thirtieth. The heated pool. The tablet the waiter never got to hand you. Your phone in your pocket, heavy with one line you haven't shown anyone.

Here's what it says. A loan servicing notice. Your parents' mortgage. Final payment received. Balance: \$0.00. Paid in full.

Eight years of \$800 envelopes on the kitchen table. Every one of them sent to the principal. Eleven years of payments finished in eight. The house you've been laughed at for living in doesn't belong to the bank anymore. It belongs to the two people who left the porch light on.

You've been paying a mortgage this whole time. Just not someone else's.

The party thins out after midnight. Theo and Jenna leave first, because their dog has been alone since six. Marcus disappears into a group of coworkers. And then it's just you and Priya at the railing, the city spread out below like a circuit board.

She doesn't look at you. She just says it.

So when are you actually moving out?

The same question. Eight years later. On a different roof.

For eight years, this is where you've said soon.

This time you take out your phone. You open the account. Not the mortgage. The other one. And you set it face up on the railing between you.

\$214,000.

Priya looks at it for a long time. She doesn't say wow. She doesn't ask how. She just goes quiet, the way you do when a story you thought you knew turns out to be a different story.

How long? she finally asks.

Since the driveway, you say. Since the four boxes. She asks if your parents know. You tell her about the mortgage. About the envelopes. About your mother's finger on the number. Priya

turns back to the city and doesn't say anything for a while. Then she says, that's the most grown-up thing anyone on this roof has done.

She laughs once, softly, not at you. We all thought you were stuck, she says.

And you give her the only true thing you have left.

For a while, you say. I was.

Three weeks later, you sign for a small house on the east side. A two-family. You'll live in one half. The other half pays for itself. You put down forty percent. The loan officer reads your file twice, then looks up at you with a different face than the one he walked in with. He'd seen the address on your application. Your parents' address. He'd assumed. Now he asks if you'd like coffee. He walks you to the elevator himself. He tells you to call his cell, not the office line.

Your last night at home, you stand on your old bed and peel the stars off the ceiling. One by one. Thirty of them come off clean. One won't let go. You leave it there.

Downstairs, your mother is at the kitchen table, holding the spare key on the faded blue lanyard. She tries to give it back to you. You close her hand around it.

Keep it, you tell her. I'll need it.

On the porch, your father is sitting in the chair he couldn't get out of on his own a year ago. He stands up without help. He shakes your hand like you're someone he just met and likes. Then the porch light comes on behind him. Same as every night. Nobody touched the switch. It's on a timer now. He set it the week you moved home.

It started with a number on a rental app. \$1,700 a month. The money changed what you were free to choose. The silence changed what you were willing to say. And the house you were laughed at for living in was never someone else's.